

WORKING BACKWARDS

Explain the process. Walk through a complete case.

A 90-minute case walkthrough for product and technology teams

Today's walkthrough

A complete Working Backwards case, from promise to decision

Fictional completed case

Ambiguity turns collaboration into risky handoffs

Working Backwards makes the promise, evidence, and decision right explicit.

A handoff becomes risky when...

The team moves before agreeing what is promised, what is known, or who decides.

Promise

Mechanisms start before the customer outcome is agreed.

Evidence

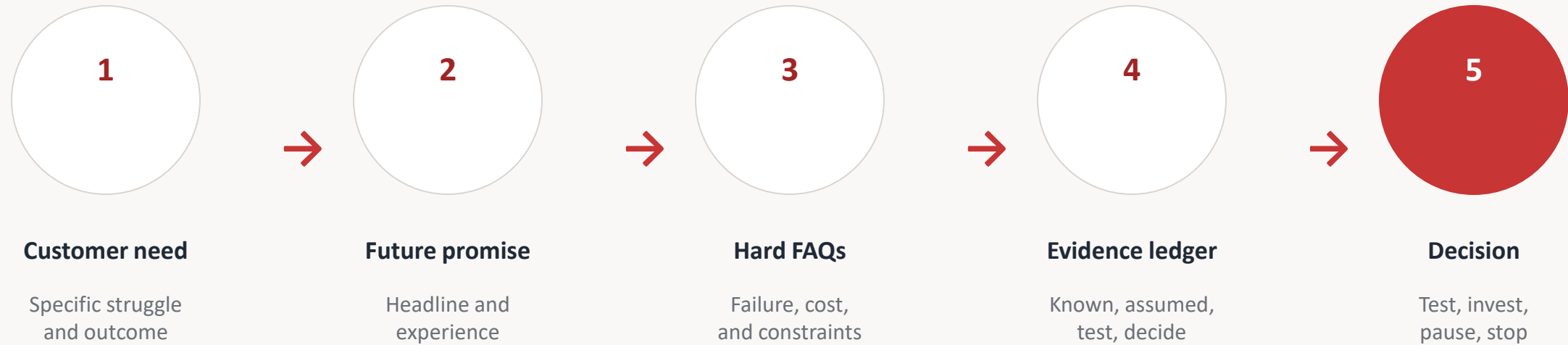
Facts and assumptions are discussed with the same confidence.

Decision right

Many people contribute, but no single person owns the decision.

Working Backwards turns opinions into testable promises

The loop moves from customer need to a decision-ready experiment.



Repeat when an FAQ breaks the promise or evidence changes the decision.

A PR/FAQ is a decision tool, not launch copy

Press release clarifies value; FAQs expose cost, risk, and evidence.

FUTURE PRESS RELEASE

Outcome-led headline

Who benefits, what becomes possible, and the boundary that keeps the promise honest.

Experience narrative

Request → confirmation → delivery → recovery

Illustrative success signal

Measure + boundary + evidence status

FAQs force five kinds of clarity

- | | | |
|----|-------------|--|
| 01 | Customer | Who is eligible? What happens on failure? |
| 02 | Feasibility | What must be technically and operationally true? |
| 03 | Quality | What evidence supports release confidence? |
| 04 | Economics | Which incremental costs change the decision? |
| 05 | Learning | What result expands, iterates, pauses, or stops? |

Today's case is fictional—and tightly bounded

Digikala Instant Exchange is an illustrative case study, not a real initiative.

Request in app → reserve same SKU → one courier visit → swap

IN

- Digikala-fulfilled
- In stock, same SKU
- Non-heavy products
- Selected reasons
- Three selected Tehran zones

OUT

- Different product, color, or size
- Seller-fulfilled or heavy items
- General returns redesign
- Instant refund or open substitution
- National or permanent launch

One customer. One struggle. One observable outcome.

This is the completed answer to align on before discussing mechanisms.

CUSTOMER	STRUGGLE	OUTCOME
Customer with a defective or incorrect eligible item	Needs it soon; today's recovery adds delay and uncertainty	Complete a same-SKU exchange within 48 hours
Still needs the product soon	Return · refund · reorder cycle	≥80% of confirmed exchanges
01TARGET CUSTOMER	02CURRENT STRUGGLE	03OBSERVED OUTCOME
		Completed model answer

Write the promise before the mechanism

The future customer experience is concrete enough to question and test.

Eligible customer can replace a bad item in one visit

- | | | |
|---|-------------------|---|
| 1 | Headline | One-visit same-SKU exchange |
| 2 | Benefit | Less effort, delay, and uncertainty |
| 3 | Experience | Request → reserve → schedule → swap → fallback |
| 4 | Signal | ≥80% complete within 48 hours |
| 5 | Boundary | Eligible items, reasons, and three Tehran zones |

3 checks

- | | |
|---|---------------------------------|
| 1 | Value
need |
| 2 | Flow
observable |
| 3 | Boundary
honest scope |

Hard FAQs expose the cost of the promise

Hard FAQs expose feasibility, failure, policy, quality, and cost.



Answers become guardrails, experiments, and stop conditions.

Label facts, assumptions, experiments, and decisions

The completed ledger makes uncertainty actionable.



Ledger example

Statement	Type	Impact	How to learn	Owner / date
Replacement stock stays reserved until the swap completes.	Assumption	High	Shadow reservation; measure loss and reconciliation.	Tech lead Before live pilot

Reversible: zones and volume cap. Hard to reverse: payment policy and architecture.

A complete PR/FAQ ends with a bounded recommendation

It is useful when it changes what the team tests, owns, or stops.

PRESS RELEASE

One-visit exchange pilot

Eligible customers request a reserved same-SKU replacement, completed in one courier visit.

RECOMMENDATION

Proceed to staged validation

Prototype, shadow-test reservation, and simulate operations before a sponsor ratifies a capped live pilot.



Promise



Guardrails



Decision

One decision, one DRI

Collaboration stays broad; accountability becomes singular.

DECISION	DRI
Customer outcome + PR/FAQ	Product manager
Experience evidence + interaction	Designer
Capacity + execution health	Engineering manager
Technical direction + feasibility	Tech lead
Implementation evidence	Named engineer
Test strategy + release confidence	QA
Metrics + learning validity	Data analyst
Irreversible investment / policy	Named sponsor

Sponsor rule

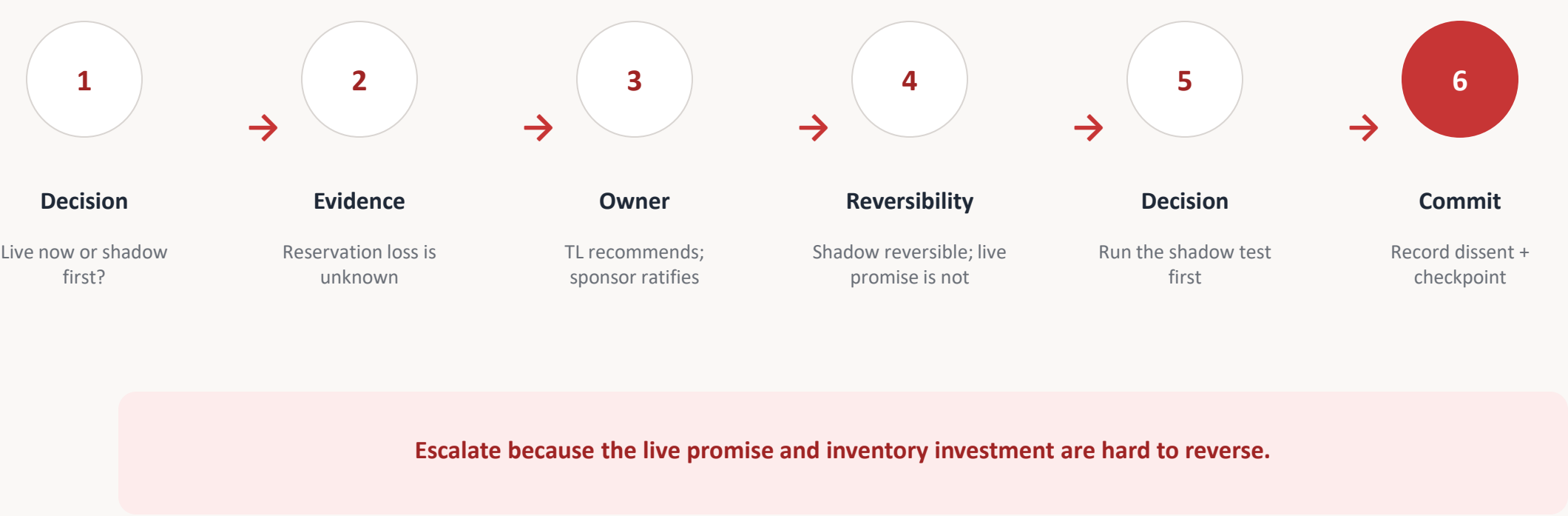
For each irreversible or investment decision, name one ratifying Product or Engineering Sponsor as DRI. Record the other sponsor's concurrence or objection.

Why one DRI?

Integrates input.
Records and owns the decision.

A written finish line resolves disagreement

Worked conflict: live pilot now, or shadow reservation first?



Stage evidence before expanding exposure

Each stage buys specific learning while keeping the decision reversible.

COMPLETED EXPERIMENT PLAN

- | | | |
|----|--------------------------------------|---|
| 01 | Customer evidence + prototype | 5–8 interviews; test value, comprehension, recovery, and accessibility. |
| 02 | Shadow reservation | Controlled SKUs; measure reservation loss, expiry, and reconciliation. |
| 03 | Operations simulation | Internal dry runs; test safety, custody, capacity, and failure codes. |
| 04 | Capped live pilot + review | ≤500 invitations; decide expand, iterate, pause, or stop. |

Live only after entry evidence passes and a sponsor ratifies.

Working Backwards makes better decisions

Make the promise, evidence, boundary, and decision right explicit.

01 Customer first

Name the struggle and observable outcome

02 Future promise

Write experience and boundary before mechanism

03 Evidence

Label assumptions; run the cheapest credible tests

04 Ownership

One DRI, a written decision, and a ratifying sponsor

Questions? Challenge the promise, evidence, or owner.